

Plastic

Try getting through a day without touching something made of plastic. This flexible friend can be molded into shape, and then sets solid. It is used to make many of the things we use every day.

The MOLDABLE MATERIAL that shaped the world



Bakelite was heatproof and did not conduct electricity.

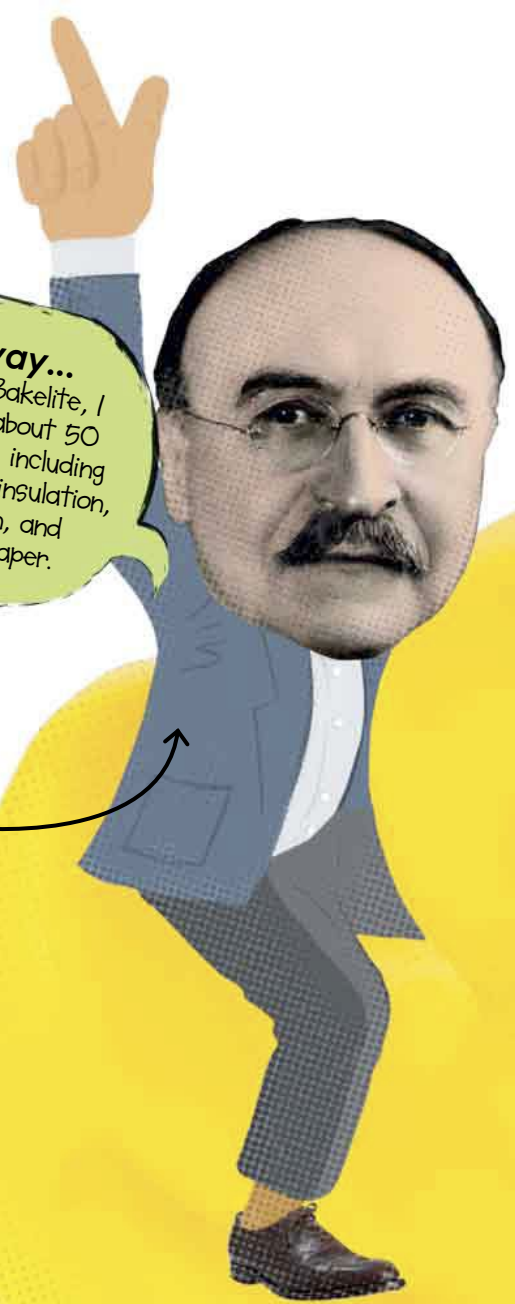
Fantastic plastic

People have used **natural materials**, such as **rubber** and **tortoiseshell**, for thousands of years, shaping them into hard-wearing objects. In 1905, Belgian-born chemist **LEO BAEKELAND** mixed phenol (a disinfectant) with formaldehyde (a preservative) and came up with Bakelite, **the first completely human-made plastic**. This versatile material can be molded into shape, but sets hard and doesn't melt easily. It was used to make music records, furniture, jewelry, and this radio cover.

By the way...

In addition to Bakelite, I also patented about 50 other inventions, including types of electric insulation, synthetic resin, and photographic paper.

Leo Baekeland received the US patent for his invention in 1909.



It couldn't have happened without...

Around **1600 BCE**, people in Mesoamerica played games with **RUBBER BALLS** made from latex—a natural plastic found in rubber trees.



American **CHARLES GOODYEAR** invented vulcanization in 1839, which made rubber stretchy but also able to **BOUNCE BACK INTO SHAPE**.

